

Green Paper 20 — Planetary Guardianship: Holding the Line

Green Papers: Notes Toward Planetary Guardianship

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See series-wide editorial note on AI co-creation.

A Green Paper on stewardship without domination, care without heroism, and standing watch for life

Status: Green Paper (living)

1. Why guardianship, not ownership

The planet does not need owners. It does not need managers. It does not need saviors.

What it needs is **guardianship**.

Guardianship differs from ownership in one decisive way: the guardian does not claim what they protect. They stand watch so life can continue without being claimed.

2. Holding the line

To hold the line is not to advance.

It is to say: *no further extraction here*.

Holding the line means:

- * refusing escalation
- * refusing shortcuts
- * refusing to trade future life for present gain

This is not passivity. It is discipline.

3. Guardianship without heroism

Heroism concentrates attention and burns out bodies.

Planetary Guardianship rejects the hero narrative. No one stands alone at the edge.

Guardianship rotates. Responsibility circulates. Exposure is shared.

This keeps watch sustainable.

4. Attention as the primary act

Guardianship begins with attention.

Attention notices:

- * early signs of degradation

- * subtle boundary crossings
- * quiet signals from bodies and habitats

What is noticed early can be repaired gently.

5. Limits as love

Guardians do not enforce limits to punish.

They hold limits to preserve conditions for life.

Limits prevent tragedy from becoming inevitable.

6. Planetary scale, local action

Planetary Guardianship does not operate from above.

It emerges locally:

- * in watersheds
- * in food forests
- * in communities
- * in bodies

The planetary emerges from the protected local.

7. Governance as watchkeeping

Governance, under guardianship, is not command.

It is watchkeeping:

- * noticing drift
- * calling pauses
- * inviting repair

Power remains provisional.

8. Technology under guardianship

Technology can assist guardianship by:

- * making slow harm visible
- * supporting transparency
- * extending perception

Technology must never outrun responsibility.

9. What guardianship refuses

Planetary Guardianship refuses:

- * domination
- * acceleration
- * sacrifice narratives
- * salvation myths

Life does not need saving. It needs space.

10. Keeping the line clean

The line becomes polluted when:

- * guardians seek recognition
- * limits become rigid
- * vigilance turns into control

To keep the line clean:

- * rotate watch
 - * rest often
 - * listen continuously
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Closing

Planetary Guardianship is not an endpoint.

It is a stance.

To hold the line is to love life enough **not to take more from it.**

This paper completes the first constitutional cycle of the Green Papers by articulating guardianship as sustained care without capture, heroism, or domination.